

account...” The mail goes on to explain how there are millions of dollars that this chap needs to transfer to your bank account and how to do this he’ll need your account details. You will, of course, be rewarded handsomely for your services.

Identity theft has figured as a criminal activity since time immemorial. Clever thieves have always found that the best way to avoid being caught is to disguise themselves as someone else. And while they are wearing this cloak of disguise, they find it profitable to make use of the identity of the person they are impersonating. No-one needs to be told how valuable one’s credit card and bank account details are. But with more and more people using the Internet for online transactions, there is a lot of personal information being shared with a host of companies. Spammers have found an effective way to cash in on this confidence to disclose one’s personal information to legitimate sources—phishing.

6.2.1 What’s Fishy About Phishing

Phishing is essentially a clever and illegal method used by “phishers” to extract personal information about Internet users. This personal information may be in terms of credit card numbers, bank account details, passwords, and such.

What phishers use is a technique called social engineering. Basically, this means phishers know that people trust the word of someone who *seems* trustworthy. A phisher is thus able to gain the confidence of an individual by posing as someone from a seemingly trustworthy source. Then, the phisher makes the person disclose personal information about himself, and then uses it to his benefit. The Nigerian scam we mentioned above was real: in fact, it was one of the instances in phishing history that led to some landmark legal actions against phishers.

However, phishers don’t have to be that straightforward and in-your-face to gain the confidence of unsuspecting individuals. Many phishers pose as administrators of Web sites and request users to send in their passwords. Others pose as bank executives